PADHAKU
First Flight · Class 10 English

CHAPTER 8

The Sermon at Benares

NCERT Exercise Solutions

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✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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⭐ The Sermon at Benares · Before You Read

1 **What is a sermon? Is it different from a lecture or a talk? Can this word also be used in a negative way or as a joke (as in "my mother's sermon about getting my work done on time…")?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

A **sermon** is a religious or moral talk, usually given by a religious teacher or priest.

It is different from a lecture (a talk to teach a subject) or a talk (any informal speech), because a sermon gives moral or religious advice.

Yes, it can be used in a negative way or as a joke for a long, boring piece of moral advice, e.g. "my mother's sermon about getting my work done on time".

2 **Find out the meanings of the words and phrases given in the box: afflicted with, be composed, desolation, lamentation, procure, be subject to**

✔ ANSWER

- **afflicted with**: affected by suffering, disease or pain
- **be composed**: be calm and in control of one's feelings

- **desolation**: great sadness and loneliness; emptiness
- **lamentation**: expression of sorrow; weeping and wailing
- **procure**: obtain or get (something), often with effort
- **be subject to**: be likely to be affected by; be under the power of

3 **Have you heard of the Sermon on the Mount? Who delivered it? Who do you think delivered a sermon at Benares?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

The Sermon on the Mount was delivered by **Jesus Christ** (as told in the Bible).

The sermon at Benares was delivered by **Gautama Buddha**; it was his first sermon after enlightenment.

🤔 The Sermon at Benares · Thinking about the Text

1 **When her son dies, Kisa Gotami goes from house to house. What does she ask for? Does she get it? Why not?**

✔ ANSWER

She asks for **medicine** to cure her dead son. She does not get it, because the boy is already dead and no medicine can bring the dead back to life. People thought "She has lost her senses."

2 **Kisa Gotami again goes from house to house after she speaks with the Buddha. What does she ask for, the second time around? Does she get it? Why not?**

✔ ANSWER

The second time she asks for **a handful of mustard-seed** from a house where no one has lost a child, husband, parent or friend. She does not get it, because there was no house where some beloved one had not died. "The living are few, but the dead are many."

3 **What does Kisa Gotami understand the second time that she failed to understand the first time? Was this what the Buddha wanted her to understand?**

✔ ANSWER

The second time she understands that **death is common to all**; every family has lost someone, and she was being selfish in her grief. Lives "flicker up and are extinguished again", like the lights of the city.

Yes, this is exactly what the Buddha wanted her to understand: all mortals are subject to death, so the wise do not grieve.

4 **Why do you think Kisa Gotami understood this only the second time? In what way did the Buddha change her understanding?**

✔ ANSWER

The first time, she was blinded by grief and could not accept that her son was dead; she only wanted a cure. The second time, she met many people who had lost loved ones and saw for herself that death comes to every home.

The Buddha did not lecture her. He gave her a task (to find mustard-seed from a house with no death) that made her learn the truth through her **own experience**. So she understood that death is universal and that grief should not make one selfish.

5 **How do you usually understand the idea of 'selfishness'? Do you agree with Kisa Gotami that she was being 'selfish in her grief'?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Usually, **selfishness** means thinking only about oneself, one's own needs and happiness, and not caring about others.

Yes, I agree. Kisa Gotami thought only of her own loss, as if she alone had suffered. She forgot that death had come to every family and that others too had grieved. Her grief made her think only of herself, so she was 'selfish in her grief'.

🤔 The Sermon at Benares · Thinking about Language

I **This text is written in an old-fashioned style, for it reports an incident more than two millennia old. Look for the following words and phrases in the text, and try to rephrase them in more current language, based on how you understand them.**

- **give thee medicine for thy child**
- **Pray tell me**
- **Kisa repaired to the Buddha**
- **there was no house but someone had died in it**
- **kinsmen**
- **Mark!**

✔ ANSWER

Old-fashioned	Current language
give thee medicine for thy child	give you medicine for your child
Pray tell me	Please tell me
Kisa repaired to the Buddha	Kisa went to the Buddha

there was no house but someone had died in it	someone had died in every house
kinsmen	relatives / family members
Mark!	Look! / Listen! / Note this!

II **You know that we can combine sentences using words like and, or, but, yet and then. But sometimes no such word seems appropriate. In such a case we can use a semicolon (;) or a dash (—) to combine two clauses.**

She has no interest in music; I doubt she will become a singer like her mother.

The second clause here gives the speaker's opinion on the first clause. Here is a sentence from the text that uses semicolons to combine clauses. Break up the sentence into three simple sentences. Can you then say which has a better rhythm when you read it, the single sentence using semicolons, or the three simple sentences?

For there is not any means by which those who have been born can avoid dying; after reaching old age there is death; of such a nature are living beings.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Three simple sentences:

- There is not any means by which those who have been born can avoid dying.
- After reaching old age there is death.
- Of such a nature are living beings.

Better rhythm: the single sentence with semicolons. It flows smoothly and links the three ideas closely, while the three simple sentences sound short and broken.

⭐ The Sermon at Benares · Speaking

1 **The Buddha's sermon is over 2500 years old. Given below are two recent texts on the topic of grief (I. A Guide to Coping with the Death of a Loved One; II. Good Grief by Amitai Etzioni). Read the texts, comparing them with each other and with the Buddha's sermon.**

Do you think the Buddha's ideas and way of teaching continue to hold meaning for us? Or have we found better ways to deal with grief? Discuss this in groups or in class.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Points for discussion:

- **Buddha's sermon:** death is common to all; weeping does not bring back the dead and only increases our pain; the wise accept it calmly and overcome sorrow.

- **Text I (A Guide to Coping):** grief is natural and personal; it shows as sadness, anger, guilt, anxiety, loneliness, fatigue and disbelief; we should be patient and reach out to grieving people.
- **Text II (Good Grief):** there is no 'right' way to grieve; the writer is still angry; his family finds comfort in asking 'what' (not 'why') and in keeping busy helping one another.
- **Comparison:** the Buddha asks us to accept death and give up grief; the modern texts accept grief as natural and stress care and support from others.
- **Conclusion:** the Buddha's ideas still hold meaning: accepting death and not being selfish in grief brings peace. His way of teaching through experience is powerful. Modern ideas add that we should let people grieve in their own way and support them. Both together help us deal with grief.

⭐ The Sermon at Benares · Writing

1 **Write a page (about three paragraphs) on one of the following topics. You can think about the ideas in the text that are relevant to these topics, and add your own ideas and experiences to them.**

1. Teaching someone to understand a new or difficult idea

2. Helping each other to get over difficult times

3. Thinking about oneself as unique, or as one among billions of others

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Helping Each Other to Get Over Difficult Times (model answer on topic 2)

Life is not always smooth. Everyone faces difficult times such as the death of a loved one, illness, failure in exams or loss of money. At such times a person feels lonely and helpless. Kisa Gotami felt the same when her only son died. She went from house to house, but she found peace only when she saw that every family had faced loss. Sharing pain makes it lighter.

We can help others in many simple ways. We can listen to them patiently, visit them, help with daily work, or just sit with them. In 'Good Grief', the writer's family kept busy calling each other, playing with little Max and staying with the young widow. Such small acts of care give great comfort. We should not force people to stop grieving; we should let them know that we are there for them.

Last year, when my friend's father was in hospital, our class shared his notes and helped him prepare for exams. He told us later that our support gave him strength. Difficult times teach us that we are not alone. When we help each other, we become stronger as a family, a school and a society.

🤔 For Anne Gregory · Thinking about the Poem

0 **This poem is a conversation between a young man and a young woman. What are they arguing about?**

✔ ANSWER

They are arguing about whether a woman can be loved **for herself alone** (her inner self) and not for her outer beauty, her 'yellow hair'. The young man says no man will love her only for herself; she says she can dye her hair so that she is loved for herself.

1 **What does the young man mean by "great honey-coloured / Ramparts at your ear?" Why does he say that young men are "thrown into despair" by them?**

✔ ANSWER

He means the young woman's **thick, golden-yellow hair** falling over her ears like the high walls (ramparts) of a fort.

Young men are “thrown into despair” because they are deeply attracted by her beautiful hair and feel hopeless about winning her love; her beauty is like a fort they cannot get past.

2 **What colour is the young woman’s hair? What does she say she can change it to? Why would she want to do so?**

✔ ANSWER

Her hair is **yellow** (golden / honey-coloured). She says she can dye it **brown, black or carrot** (orange). She wants to do so, so that young men love her for herself alone (her inner qualities) and not for her beautiful yellow hair.

3 **Objects have qualities which make them desirable to others. Can you think of some objects (a car, a phone, a dress...) and say what qualities make one object more desirable than another? Imagine you were trying to sell an object: what qualities would you emphasise?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- **Car:** good mileage, safety features, comfort, looks, brand and price.
- **Phone:** good camera, long battery life, fast processor, large storage, nice design, reasonable price.

- **Dress:** good fabric, colour, design, comfort, fashion and fitting.

If I were selling a phone, I would stress its **excellent camera, long battery life, speed, stylish look and value for money**, and any free gifts or warranty.

4 **What about people? Do we love others because we like their qualities, whether physical or mental? Or is it possible to love someone "for themselves alone"? Are some people 'more lovable' than others? Discuss this question in pairs or in groups, considering points like the following.**

(i) a parent or caregiver's love for a newborn baby, for a mentally or physically challenged child, for a clever child or a prodigy

(ii) the public's love for a film star, a sportsperson, a politician, or a social worker

(iii) your love for a friend, or brother or sister

(iv) your love for a pet, and the pet's love for you.

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Points for discussion:

- **(i)** A parent loves a newborn baby, a challenged child or a clever child equally and without conditions. This is love "for themselves alone", not for qualities.

- **(ii)** The public loves a film star, sportsperson, politician or social worker for their looks, talent, power or good work. This love depends on qualities and may fade when these are lost.
- **(iii)** We love a friend or brother or sister for their company, care and shared memories. It starts with qualities but grows into love for the person.
- **(iv)** A pet loves its owner without conditions; we love a pet for its loyalty and affection.

Conclusion: most love begins with qualities, but true love (like a parent's or a pet's) is for the person alone. Some people may seem 'more lovable' because of their qualities, but everyone deserves love.

5 **You have perhaps concluded that people are not objects to be valued for their qualities or riches rather than for themselves. But elsewhere Yeats asks the question: How can we separate the dancer from the dance? Is it possible to separate 'the person himself or herself' from how the person looks, sounds, walks, and so on? Think of how you or a friend or member of your family has changed over the years. Has your relationship also changed? In what way?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

It is not fully possible to separate a person from how he or she looks, speaks or behaves; these are part of the person, just as the dance is part of the dancer. But the inner self (nature, values, love) matters more than looks.

For example, my grandfather was once strong and active; now he is old and walks slowly. His looks have changed, but our love for him has not. Our relationship has grown deeper: earlier he took care of me, now I help him and listen to his stories. So relationships change in form, but true love remains for the person himself.

🎉 **Chapter 8 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**